Strokkur Geyser

A famous Icelandic geyser, which erupts roughly every eight minutes

Strokkur geyser is situated in an area of hot springs about 50 miles (80 km) east of Iceland's capital, Reykjavík. Nearby is another famous but less frequently erupting geyser, named Geysir, which was first described in 1294 and gave the world the word "geyser."

Strokkur first became active following an earthquake in 1789. The geyser erupts from a pool of water, and its typical eruption height is about 50–65 ft (15–20 m), but occasionally the fountain of hot water reaches 130 ft (40 m). Each blast lasts for just a few seconds and is accompanied by a dramatic explosion of sound.

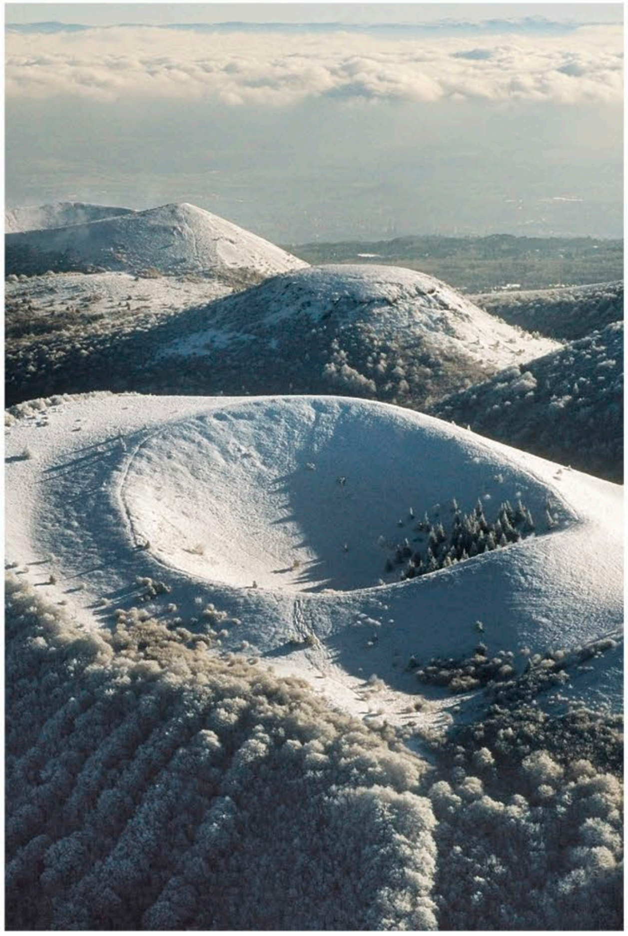
△ **REGULAR CYCLE**
The geyser's eight-minute cycle owes its regularity to human intervention. In 1963, its conduit was cleaned to ensure regular eruptions.

◁ **READY TO BLOW**
When Strokkur erupts, first a dome of water bulges up as a steam bubble rises from below. A plume of boiling water then blasts violently skyward.

The Massif Central

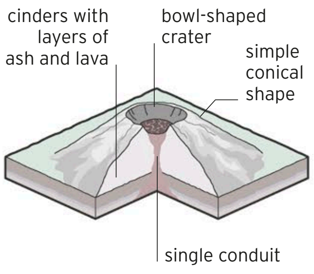
A highland region of France with a superlative scenery of extinct volcanoes

Covering about one-seventh of France, the Massif Central is separated from the Alps by the valley of the Rhône. Volcanism began here about 65 million years ago—possibly due to crustal thinning and upwelling of hot mantle rock—and is apparent today as volcanic remnants, known as the Chaîne des Puys, across a northern part of the region. The southern part of the massif features raised limestone plateaus cut through by deep canyons. The most famous of these is the magnificent Tarn Gorge, which is 33 miles (53 km) long and in places up to 2,000 ft (600 m) deep.



INSIDE A CINDER CONE

Pyroclastic, or cinder, cones are relatively small, steep-sided volcanoes built mainly from loose volcanic cinders (glassy fragments of solidified lava). Some also contain volcanic ash. Most have just one main eruptive phase when they first appear. After erupting and growing for a few months to years, they go permanently quiet.



◁ **THE CHAÎNE DES PUYS**
This line of small, extinct volcanoes, mostly in the form of cinder cones, is about 25 miles (40 km) long. Puy de Côme is shown in the foreground with a winter sprinkling of snow.